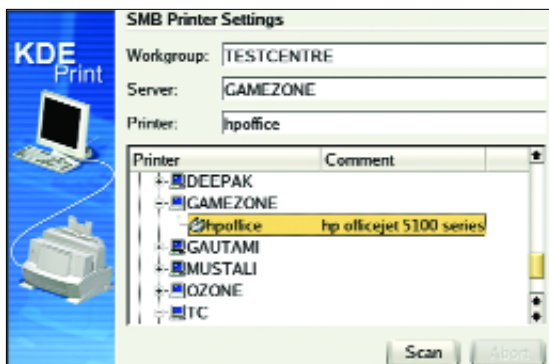




This scan button helps you browse through the network and install remote printers

Red Hat turned out to be the worst of the lot—Samba isn't installed by default, so at first logon you can't access a remote share. Even after installing Samba, you need to get down to the command prompt to enable sharing, enable the samba server and mount remote shares. It would be better to just switch to Konqueror, instead of the default file manager, to graphically browse shares.

ELX offers the least flexibility—if you want to share any folder, you have to copy the entire folder to `/home/public`, which, in fact, is the only folder that is accessible to others.

Sharing files has always been a bane for Linux users. Advanced users can edit the `/etc/samba/smb.conf` file in order to enable file-sharing.

Xandros treats each LAN connection as a dial-up. You can specify this LAN-based dial-up to connect at login, and also which users are allowed to use this connection—great for security.

Linux deals with networking very efficiently. SuSE and ELX provide local network browsing, just as in Windows. You can browse through the network and even see hidden Windows shares, also called dollar shares. You can copy files by dragging and dropping, and view the details of the elapsed and required time, as well as the data transfer progress in MB.

Printing

Setting up a local printer seems to be an easy task these days, thanks to new GUI tools, but connecting to a remote printer is still tough. ELX lets you browse through the network and



SuSE and ELX provide local network browsing, just like Windows

Case Study Mahiti

“Linux is more stable and secure than Windows”



Sunil Abraham

MAHITI SPECIALISES IN multi-platform, multi-lingual Web, intranet, multimedia and kiosk applications. Sunil Abraham founded Mahiti in 1998 along with Sreekanth and Allan to provide appropriate and affordable IT services to the voluntary sector. They started by providing free e-mail service and Web sites for around 20 organisations. They built over 50 Web, Intranet, kiosk and multimedia applications for clients—including Ashoka.org, Indian Foundation for the Arts, United Nations Development Programme, National Law School University of India, Tarahaat.com and Explocity.com.

Currently, Sunil is the team leader at Mahiti. His responsibilities include marketing, client liaison, design, documentation, project management, production and technical or non-technical training. We spoke to him regarding his company's shift to Linux:

Why did you shift from Windows to Linux?

The primary issue was the licensing that is involved in procuring commercial software such as Microsoft Windows.

How much did you save by switching to Linux?

It is very difficult to calculate, can't say. When we used Windows, we had only few shareware programmes. Now we have several mature applications. The average Linux distribution comes with 2,000 applications.

How much did you spend, training people to use Linux?

We did not spend any money as the training was handled by a volunteer, Pramod R—a member of the local Linux User Group [LUG] from Bangalore.

What are the immediate advantages achieved?

As a software development company, using Linux we spend less money to procure third party licenses and therefore for the same revenue we make more profit.

What were the problems during and after shift over?

Users were not used to the small differences between Linux and Windows. For example copying and pasting, copying of files across the network, installing fonts, etc.

Are you satisfied with Linux?

Yes, Very.

Five common problems that your people faced while using Linux?

1. OpenOffice.org is too slow
2. No application to replace software such as 3dsMax and AutoCAD
3. No easy tools to configure scanners, printer and the like
4. No applications for audio or video editing
5. No wizards for installing fonts, keymaps, locales

If Windows offered you a free license, would you switch back?

We will shift to Microsoft only for its office suite. Provided it is available under GPL. But we will not shift from Linux as the operating system, even if Microsoft becomes 'free as in freedom' and 'free as in free beer'. This is because Linux is more stable, more secure and completely virus free. We don't have to keep giving three-finger salutes throughout the day.

How many people in your organisation?

We have 15 employees working here.

How many of them have a technical background?

Being a software development company most of us are programmers.

How many of them had already used Linux before?

Almost none had previous Linux experience.

What was the employee reaction to the switch?

Initially, the reaction was, "This is very difficult", but they got used to it eventually. The option I gave them was pay for your own software. Needless to say, no one took that option.